

considered the first user-friendly handwriting recognition input device. It used an array of touch sensitive sensors on the 10 x 10 foot pad to detect the position of the pen and transmit the x and y coordinates to the computer. The Rand tablet used Ellis' handwriting recognition software GRAIL (GRAphic Input Language) to convert the readings into meaningful content.

AI Advances: Expert Systems

Edward Feigenbaum, Joshua Lederberg, and Bruce Buchanan began developing the Dendral expert system. (An expert system is a computer program that can form intelligent opinion based on related information provided to it about a specific subject.) Lederberg was an organic chemist of repute who was considering the problems faced by his brethren when trying to discover the molecular structure of organic compounds. Feigenbaum, who was researching artificial intelligence, decided to create an artificial expert in a particular subject area to study the limits to which a computer could come to conclusions autonomously. The expert system, to be successful, should be first fed with information about the particular subject. Based on this established database, the expert system then applied rules to arrive at conclusions.

CAD Emerges

The DAC-1 (Design Augmented by Computers) computer-aided design program was released. Development began in 1959, with General Motors Research Laboratories exploring the use of computers in designing automobiles, in collaboration with IBM. DAC-1 involved the use of a light pencil that identified coordinates of its position on a conductive transparent sheet placed over the display console.

Something Like GPS

The US Navy's Navigational Satellite system (NAVSAT) becomes operational. Also called TRANSIT system, it used six satellites to identify the position of submarines to within a 200-metre accuracy. The TRANSIT is the predecessor of the present day GPS (Global Positioning System).